FOR A SMOOTH RIDE



The introduction of 45 contactless services by the transport department of Assam has not only set a new benchmark in public service delivery but also saved more than 3.6 million man-days and generated economic benefit of around Rs 180 crore.

■ BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT ■

On September 17 this year, the day the entire country was in a jubilant mood celebrating the birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, he gifted the country a path-breaking policy—the National Logistics Policy (NLP). India's logistics cost as a proportion of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) is believed to be around 13-14 per cent. The new policy not only aims to bring down that share to single digits as soon as possible but also revolutionise the transport sector. "To ensure quick last mile delivery, end transport-related challenges, save time and money of the manufacturers, prevent wastage of the agro-products, concerted efforts were made and one of the manifestations of those efforts is the National Logistics Policy," said the Prime Minister.

One of the key components of this policy is the adoption of technology to strengthen the logistic and transportation sector. For instance, the Prime Minister launched the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP) that will bring all the digital services related to the transportation sector into a single portal, freeing the exporters from a host of very long and cumbersome processes. A new digital platform—Ease of logistics Services or E-Logs—has also been launched, through which industry associations can take up any issues pertaining to operations and performance with the government.

Taking cue from the Prime Minister, 14 states, including Assam, have already formed their logistics policy. But successful implementation of the policy depends on efficient adoption of technology, particularly in the transport sector. That's the reason, the Assam government, led by Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma has heralded an unprecedented digital revolution in the transport sector. Today, a citizen can access almost all transport-related services at the click of a mouse, from the comfort of his or her home. "We are setting new benchmarks in efficient and hassle-free public service delivery. In pursuance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, all efforts are being made to minimise compliance burden for common people in obtaining government services. These online services are a step in that direction," says Chief Minister Sarma.

When Covid restrictions discouraged assembling of public, the transport department in Assam was in an urgent need to devise a process in service delivery so that people could be given the option to access to transport-related services without even visiting the DTO (District Transport Offices). Even though transport-related services through Sarathi 4.0 and Vahan 4.0—the existing processes in service delivery—were online, people still needed to physically visit the DTOs. It resulted in loss of several precious man-days, besides causing inconvenience to people. There were issues related to delay in delivery of services and lack of transparency.

Easing the processes became the need of the